

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The DfE's twin SEND reform consultations — on education otherwise than at school (EOTAS) and a new 'local SEND inclusion formula' funding mainstream schools upfront — close at 11.59pm tonight.
→ **For your school:** Last call to get any outstanding MAPs school responses in before the deadline.
- Sheffield City Council is bringing a new learning places strategy to committee, proposing extra specialist SEND places and a 'joined-up approach' to exclusions and alternative provision after a sustained rise in both.
→ **For your school:** Worth tracking as it moves through committee — directly touches AP and SEND placements for partner schools.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

18 Sep 2026 — DfE's twin SEND/EOTAS reform consultations close tonight at 11.59pm.

24 Sep 2026 — Deadline for academy trusts to submit their budget forecast return, per this week's DfE Update.

■ INCLUSION, SEND & ALTERNATIVE PROVISION

- **SEND/EOTAS consultations close today.** The DfE's linked consultations on reforming education otherwise than at school and on a new local SEND inclusion formula — which would front-load more SEND funding to mainstream schools rather than via top-ups — both close at 11.59pm tonight. Existing EHCPs stay protected until 2030; the government's response is expected in autumn. (GOV.UK)
→ **For your school:** If any MAPs partner school hasn't responded, today is the last chance.

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **New learning places strategy aims to tackle SEND demand and exclusions together.** Councillors are considering a city-wide learning places strategy proposing extra specialist SEND places and a joined-up approach linking exclusions, alternative provision and SEND placement decisions — responding to a sustained rise in both exclusions and SEND demand. Children with SEND, from disadvantaged backgrounds and from ethnic minority communities remain over-represented in exclusion figures, the report notes. ([Sheffield City Council](#))
→ **For your school:** Flag to partner schools once a committee date is confirmed — this is the strategy that will shape AP commissioning locally.

■ NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

- **DfE pushes back two autumn deadlines.** This week's DfE Update moves the operational deadline for autumn-census free school meal eligibility checks from 1 October to 2 November, giving schools more time to implement the new Universal Credit-based FSM expansion, while academy trusts get until 24 September for budget forecast returns. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update, 16 September 2026\)](#))
→ **For your school:** Useful breathing room if FSM re-checks are still in progress for MAPs schools.

JARGON-BUSTER - EOTAS

Cropping up a lot in today's SEND coverage:

Education Otherwise Than At School — provision for children who can't attend a mainstream or special school placement, e.g. home tuition, hospital education or approved online providers. Tonight's consultation proposes new statutory guidance for how councils commission and quality-assure it.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.